



Add captions wherever possible

thin fonts on your website or have font-size set to an abysmally low number, then your website will be a pain to go through for people experiencing blurred vision.

Again, the Developer Tools included in all the popular web browsers have tools which can simulate blurry vision. You can access these by first opening Developer Tools (Ctrl + Shift + C) and then opening the command line (Ctrl + Shift + P) and typing in Rendering. Once you enable the Rendering drawer, you can emulate Vision Deficiencies such as Blurred Vision and different forms of colour blindness. This is also a relatively easy fix to implement since all you need to ensure is that your fonts are legible, and headers are large enough.

CAPTIONS AND ALT-TEXTS

We use a lot of images and videos on our websites. These are great at conveying messages in a more lucid and concise manner compared to plain text. However, they also present new challenges for the visually impaired. A screen reader tool or narrator cannot do anything about images except call out the existence of said image on the web page but if you were to put an alt-text for the image describing exactly being portrayed in the image, then you've made your site a little accessible. The same logic applies to URLs as well. Providing a descriptive text for a URL rather than simply calling it a link would be more helpful for the visually impaired. If you had ten links on a page with proper descriptive text stating where each link will lead the user to, would be helpful. Another important reason for having descrip-

tive text is that search engines such as Google and Bing rank your page better if you include the same.

In a similar fashion, if you have video embedded on your website you should always have a caption that states what the video is about. And for the hearing impaired, it would be great to include closed captions. Popular video websites such as YouTube now have auto-captioning services on the video which can be turned on by default while embedding a video. For better accuracy, you can even submit a subtitle file to YouTube and the same might get incorporated into the video if the video uploader approves.

KEYBOARD FRIENDLY

Not everyone has the privilege of using a mouse or a touch screen to navigate a website. Visually impaired individuals and those with motor-function impairment use Braille keyboards or specialised key-pads to navigate website and they often use the arrow keys along with the tab key move the cursor across the web site. You can ensure that the interactive elements are lined up in a sequence for this reason. There are HTML attributes and event handlers to direct focus of the cursor.

'Tabindex' is a global HTML attribute which specifies the tabbing order of the element. It is advisable to keep the 'tabindex' to '0' for all elements on your website. Adding the 'tabindex' attribute also makes

the element focusable. Then there are the event handlers which decide what happens when a certain key is pressed. Since arrow keys are commonly used to navigate websites you can use the 'onkeydown' and 'onkeyup' event handlers to direct the cursor or execute a specific function.

The last element is to make an element that is currently focused visible. If your website has tonnes of focusable elements, then the cursor or highlighted element can easily get lost. To remedy this, use the 'onfocus' CSS pseudo-class. This way you can give a special styling to



Ensure easy navigation using a keyboard

the element under focus and make it stand out from the rest of the elements on the page.

THERE IS MORE...

These were some of the key considerations for ensuring that your website is accessible to all. It is quite easy to overlook all the aspects we have mentioned on this page simply because we have not or do not experience the difficulties that a sizeable chunk of the human population does. However, it is not difficult to ensure that a web site is made accessible to all. While we have covered most of the major steps that you can take there are some more situational considerations as well. If you ensure that accessibility is paramount from the very beginning of the design process, you should be good. Always remember to design a website for the visitor and not for yourself. 🇮🇳